

Pre-Week 1 Playbook: NFL Props + CFB Spreads

Status: Paper trading through August → Live by Week 1

Timeline: ~3 weeks

Deployment: Multi-book NFL props + CFB spreads + 2-3u per bet

PART 1: NFL PROPS — OPENING LINE TRACKING & EDGE DETECTION

Phase 1A: Semi-Manual Line Tracking Setup (Week 1 of August)

Daily workflow (20 mins/day):

At 10 AM ET (when most openers drop):

DraftKings: Screenshot or manually note prop lines for the week

FanDuel: Same

BetMGM: Same

Store in a **simple Google Sheet** or local CSV with schema:



Date | Book | Game | Player | Market | Side | Line | Price | Timestamp

Compare to your model:

For each game, run your edge-index model

Flag bets where **price_taken > your edge threshold** (based on 2026 audit: +1.5% minimum after CLV adjustment)

Track which book is sharpest (typically the one with tightest books first)

Decision rule for paper trading:

Tier 1 (Bet): Model edge $\geq +2.0\%$ AND available at ≤ -110 price

Tier 2 (Consider): Model edge +1.5% to +2.0% at ≤ -115 price

Tier 3 (Skip): Below +1.5% edge or fading risk too high

Why semi-manual?

You get familiar with book behavior (which sharpens first, which has wishy-washy openers)

Low lift to automate later; high signal now

Prevents over-reliance on automation during model validation

Phase 1B: Closing Line Value (CLV) Tracking

You learned from the 2026 audit: CLV exists (+2.4%), but closing lines move against you (-20.7pp average).

New tracking protocol:

When you place a paper bet at price X, **log the closing price immediately before game time**

At end of week, calculate actual CLV realized

Goal: Track if your placement timing (hours before kickoff) correlates with CLV capture

Hypothesis to test:

Bets placed 48-72 hours before kickoff: minimal fading (you had +2.1% ROI at this window last year)

Bets placed <12 hours: worst fading (you had -6.0% ROI)

Action: Restrict placement window to 48-96 hours before kickoff for first 3 weeks

Tracking columns:


Bet_ID Price_Taken Hours_Before_Kickoff Close_Same Close_Opp
Actual_CLV Result Realized_Return

Phase 1C: By-Market Performance Bucketing

From your 2026 data, **two markets showed real edge:**

rec_yds: 57.58% W%, +8.62% ROI (165 bets)

receptions: 57.62% W%, +9.27% ROI (151 bets)

Three markets showed consistent losses:

pass_yds: 47.97% W%, -9.68% ROI (148 bets)

rush_att: 47.41% W%, -8.43% ROI (135 bets)

Action for 2027:

Lean into rec_yds + receptions (proven edge)

Avoid pass_yds, rush_att (model weakness)

Monitor pass_tds, longest_rec (neutral; need more data)

Allocation by market (suggested):


rec_yds: 30% of bets (highest confidence)
receptions: 25% of bets (highest confidence)
pass_att: 20% of bets (moderate; was -1.99% ROI)
longest_rec: 15% of bets (wait-and-see)
others: 10% (exploratory)

PART 2: CFB SPREADS — POWER RANKINGS & EDGE MODEL

Phase 2A: Data Assembly (This Week)

Required datasets (all publicly available):

Dataset	Source	Purpose
Historical team records	ESPN CFB schedule/standings	Win-loss by year (2021-2026)
Recruiting ranks	247Sports or Rivals	Portal + HS recruiting (lagged 1-2 years)
Returning production	ESPN CFB rosters	QB, top WR, top RB continuity
SOS/strength metrics	ESPN, Sports Reference	Avg opponent rating
Transfer portal	247Sports portal tracker	In/out transfers (affects depth, continuity)
Coaching changes	ESPN news	New coach impact (first-year effects)

Data pipeline:

1. Pull ESPN schedule for all FBS teams (2021-2026)

2. For each team, scrape:

- Record vs ranked teams

- Record in conf vs OOC

- Coach tenure

- QB starter status (returning, new, transfer)

3. Merge with recruiting ranks (lagged by 1-2 years for draft class impact)

4. Merge with 247Sports transfer portal data

5. Create feature set in Pandas DataFrame

Estimated lift: 2-3 hours to assemble; once built, reusable for validation

Phase 2B: Power Ranking Model Structure

Simple approach (high signal, low noise):

```
python
```

Pseudocode for CFB power ranking

```
def calculate_team_rating(team_df):  
    # Historical win rate (50% weight)  
    recent_wr = team_df['wins_last_3yrs'] / team_df['games_last_3yrs']  
  
    # Recruiting (30% weight)  
    # Avg recruiting rank in last 3 recruiting classes  
    avg_recruit_rank = team_df['avg_recruit_rank_3yr']  
    recruit_percentile = (335 - avg_recruit_rank) / 335 # 335 teams  
  
    # Returning production (15% weight)  
    # QB continuity + star count  
    qb_returning = 1 if team_df['qb_same'] else 0.5  
    top_wr_back = team_df['top_wr_count'] / 4 # max 4 assumed  
    continuity = (qb_returning + top_wr_back) / 2  
  
    # Coaching (5% weight)  
    coach_tenure = min(team_df['coach_years'], 3) / 3 # diminishing returns  
  
    # Composite rating  
    rating = (  
        0.50 * recent_wr +  
        0.30 * recruit_percentile +  
        0.15 * continuity +  
        0.05 * coach_tenure  
    )  
  
    return rating
```

Output: Win probability vs any opponent



If Team A has rating 0.68 and Team B has rating 0.65:
 $P(A \text{ beats } B) = 68 / (68 + 65) \approx 51.1\%$

Then compare to the spread:

Market line: A -2.5 (implies 56.3% for A)

Your model: 51.1% for A

Difference: -5.2pp → edge = -2.5 (fade A)

Phase 2C: Initial Model Calibration (2-3 Games)

Before Week 1 of CFB:

Pick 2-3 FBS games with early openers (typically Labor Day weekend)

Build power rankings for those teams

Compare to market spread

Track the results (but don't bet real money yet)

Adjust weights if the model is systematically too high/low

Calibration check:

If your model predicts 45% for Team A and market prices it at 50%, you should see Team A win ~45% of the time

If you see 55%+, your model is too pessimistic (lower weight on recent performance, raise weight on recruiting)

PART 3: PAPER TRADING INFRASTRUCTURE

Phase 3A: Tracking System

Google Sheet or local database with:



Trade_ID | Sport | Type | Game | Bet_Detail |
Price_Taken | Model_Edge% | Book | Timestamp |
Hours_Before_Game | Status | Result | Return_Units |
Closing_Price_Same | Closing_Price_Opp | Actual_CLV

Key metrics to compute daily:

Cumulative ROI by sport (NFL props, CFB spreads)

Cumulative ROI by book (DK, FanDuel, BetMGM)

Cumulative ROI by market type (rec_yds, pass_yds, spreads, etc.)

Win rate by placement timing (0-12h, 12-48h, 48-96h)

Closing line movement avg by sport

Phase 3B: Bankroll & Unit Sizing

Paper trading bankroll: 2,500-3,000 units (to accommodate 2-3u per bet)

Allocation:

NFL props: 60% of bets (1,500-1,800 units)

CFB spreads: 40% of bets (1,000-1,200 units)

Target ~**100-120 total bets in August** (20-25 per week)

Bet sizing:

Tier 1 (edge $\geq$ +2.0%): 3 units

Tier 2 (edge +1.5% to +2.0%): 2 units

Tier 3 (edge +1.0% to +1.5%): 1 unit

Monthly ROI targets:

Conservative: +1% to +2% (20-60 units profit on 2,500 bankroll)

Realistic: -2% to +3% (variance expected)

Red flag: < -5% (model drift; pause and audit)

PART 4: WEEKLY CHECKLIST (August → Week 1)

Every Monday (Pre-Week Prep)

- ☐ Pull opening lines (DK, FanDuel, BetMGM)
- ☐ Run model for all games
- ☐ Identify Tier 1 & 2 edges
- ☐ Check CFB power rankings for weekend games
- ☐ Plan paper bets for the week

Every Wednesday (Mid-Week Check)

- ☐ Verify lines haven't moved sharply
- ☐ Check for late-week injuries/news
- ☐ Place paper bets in model or spreadsheet

Every Friday (Pre-Game Final)

- ☐ Log closing prices for all open bets
- ☐ Calculate CLV realized
- ☐ Plan any last-minute adjustments

Every Sunday/Monday (Post-Game Reconcile)

- ☐ Log results (wins/losses)
- ☐ Calculate ROI by market, by book, by timing
- ☐ Identify underperforming markets (avoid next week)
- ☐ Audit any surprises

PART 5: GO/NO-GO DECISION FOR WEEK 1 LIVE DEPLOYMENT

Criteria to deploy real capital by Week 1:

Green light (proceed to live):

Paper trading through August shows +0.5% to +3% ROI (net positive or near breakeven)

Win rate $\geq$ 52% (beats -115 breakeven)

No catastrophic failures in any single market

CLV tracking shows pattern (e.g., 48-72h window captures +2% vs <12h window at -5%)

CFB power rankings backtest on 2-3 games shows calibration

Red light (extend paper trading):

ROI < -5% in August

Any single market loses > 15% (stop using immediately)

Win rate < 50% (systematic underestimation)

CFB model not yet tested on live games

Yellow light (live with caution):

August ROI between -2% and +0.5%

Win rate 50-52% (on edge of breakeven)

→ Go live with 50% of bankroll, keep 50% for paper

→ Increase to 100% once live results match paper results

PART 6: FILE STRUCTURE FOR EDGE-INDEX

Add to your edge-index repo for 2027 season:



```
edge-index/  
├── data/  
│   ├── nfl/  
│   │   ├── 2026_paper_trades.csv (audit reference)  
│   │   ├── 2027_opening_lines.csv (daily tracking)  
│   │   ├── 2027_paper_trades.csv (live as we go)  
│   │   └── market_calibration.json (rec_yds: +8.6%, pass_yds: -9.7%, etc.)  
│   ├── cfb/  
│   │   ├── team_historical.csv (records 2021-2026)  
│   │   ├── recruiting_ranks.csv (247Sports)  
│   │   ├── transfer_portal.csv (in/out by team)  
│   │   ├── power_rankings_2027.csv (your model output)  
│   │   └── cfb_paper_trades.csv (live as we go)  
│   └── closing_lines/  
│       └── clv_tracking.csv (timestamp, price_taken, close_same, close_opp)  
├── models/  
│   ├── nfl_props_2027.py (refined from 2026 audit)  
│   ├── cfb_spreads_2027.py (new model)  
│   └── calibration_tracker.py (CLV + win rate by timing/market)  
├── notebooks/  
│   ├── august_validation.ipynb (paper trading results)  
│   ├── cfb_power_ranking_backtest.ipynb (calibration on historical)  
│   └── market_performance_analysis.ipynb (rec_yds vs pass_yds, etc.)  
└── reports/  
    ├── 2027_pre_season_audit.md (this document + results)  
    └── weekly_performance_summaries/ (Aug + Sept)
```

IMMEDIATE ACTIONS (Do This Week)

By EOD Friday:

Set up Google Sheet for daily line tracking (or CSV + Python script)

Columns: Date, Book, Game, Player, Market, Line, Price, Timestamp

Share read-only link to yourself for mobile access

Build CFB dataset (2-3 hours)

Pull ESPN schedules 2021-2026

Scrape 247Sports recruiting ranks

Merge into single Pandas DataFrame

Save to `edge-index/data/cfb/team_historical.csv`

Write power ranking model (1-2 hours)

Python function that takes team_df → rating

Test on 1-2 FBS teams to verify output reasonable (e.g., Bama should be ~0.80, FCS-level team ~0.30)

Create paper trading tracker (30 mins)

Schema above in Google Sheet or local CSV

Plan for 100-120 bets in August across both sports

By Week 1 of CFB (Sept 1):

Backtest CFB power rankings on 2-3 Labor Day weekend games

Validate NFL model on Seahawks/Broncos (typical early opener)

Finalize market allocation (rec_yds: 30%, receptions: 25%, etc.)

Success Metrics for August

Metric	Target	Red Flag
NFL props ROI	+0.5% to +3%	< -5%
CFB spreads ROI	+0.5% to +2%	< -5%
Combined win rate	≥ 52%	< 50%
Placement timing	48-96h captures +2% vs <12h	Consistent fading at all windows
CFB model calibration	Predictions match outcomes within ±3% Off by >5%	
Book comparison	Identify which book is sharpest	All books equally sharp (less efficient)

By Week 1: Decision Tree

Did August paper trading hit ≥ +0.5% ROI?
— YES → Proceed to live with full bankroll (Week 1)
— 0% to -2% → Proceed to live with 50% bankroll, keep 50% paper
— < -2% → Extend paper trading through September; reassess Week 1

Key Learnings from 2026 Audit to Carry Forward

Avoid these markets: pass_yds (-9.68% ROI), rush_att (-8.43% ROI)

Double down on: rec_yds (+8.62% ROI), receptions (+9.27% ROI)

Timing matters: 48-72h window was +2.1% ROI vs <12h at -6.0%

Closing line fading is real: -20.7pp average; not random

Win rate calibration is off: 52.37% vs 53.49% implied (1.12pp miss) → Recalibrate model before Week 1

This playbook is your north star for August. Let's sync mid-August to audit results and adjust if needed.